

NSA denied!

Privacy and Civil Liberties Oversight Board states that an NSA metadata program lacks a viable legal foundation <http://dgit.in/NSAmeta>



Lincoln Navigator 2015

Check out the specs of the new Lincoln Navigator, due to launch in 2015 <http://dgit.in/lincnav15>

HOW WE TESTED

A modified version of our test process for regular speakers was used for this test. Normally our preference in **test tracks** is not this eclectic. Our discerning ears for years have been biased towards guitar-driven Rock and Metal. But for this test, we realised that this would just not work. One of the main reasons for this is that most of these speakers just can't take the complexity, layering and instrument density that goes into most Progressive Rock numbers. Our test samples previously consisted of *Between The Buried And Me*, *Motherjane* and occasionally some *Porcupine Tree*. On 90 percent of these speakers, *Selkies* sounds like noise – and that's not even when pushing the volume dial to its extreme. The only way that we could spot nuances or prowess in certain frequency ranges was if we switched over to well mixed acoustic numbers or genres that leaned more towards classical music. To mix it up a little, we zeroed in on 'Lotus Feet' by *Shakti* – a beautiful Indian Classical Jazz Fusion masterpiece with delicate flute tunes, percussions and strains from a sympathetic steel string guitar. The other reason for changing up our standard track list was the plausible use-case scenarios. These speakers are meant to be portable and will most likely be used

in outings with friends, house parties, camp fires, and other such occasions. We can't imagine a campfire where you find *Sabbath* playing; well at least not the kind normal people go to. Hence the addition of the catchy dance-pop 'Stereo Love' by *Edward Maya feat. Vika Jigulina*. As for the rest of the track selection, we used old favourites (some of which we've been using for years now) to test specific attributes such as stereo separation, vocal tonality, detail, etc. Each speaker was paired with a Nexus 5 and the test tracks were played to judge the speaker quality. The **files used** were FLAC format, fully uncompressed WAV format or at least 320 kbps MP3 format. Scores were given specific to each sample. For instance, for testing bass performance we used 'Angel' by *Massive Attack*. Other **parameters for performance** were aesthetics, build quality, loudness and range. While aesthetics was purely subjective, things like build quality were assessed based on the materials used, the finish and attention to detail. If there were gaps in the joints, points were cut while things such as covered ports were given a good score for this parameter. Range was tested by taking away the source slowly within line of sight. The best range got scores close to 20 while loudness

was judged on a scale of 100. Since loudness is important when it comes to portable speakers, this factor contributed significantly towards the performance score. Overall, **performance was given much higher weightage** as against features when calculating the final score (80:20). Within features, weights were assigned for things such as presence of NFC, battery level indicator or the ability to charge via a USB port as against a dedicated DC adaptor. Features such as the ability to charge other devices were given extra weightage. Battery level indicator was only counted as present if it showed more than three levels of calibration. Some of these speakers double up as speakers for handsfree call answering. While testing this capability, we realised that none of them really stood out – they were all pretty much the same. Hence this score was taken under features rather than being clubbed under performance. Finally, **to arrive at the best value for money proposition**, we calculated the ratio of performance per unit of price. Dividing up the speakers into logical categories based on price we then got best value for money devices within that price range. But of course, like always there was only one best performer.

caveat associated with this category and it goes something like this: it's good, for a portable speaker. And this tip still holds true. Every one of these speakers (well almost) can be described as good but only if you make concessions for them being portable. They can't hold a candle to the sound quality most regular fixed speakers would produce. But do you really care about high-fidelity audio? Or do you care about good enough (Read:loud) audio for the moment? It's like those debates technology pundits used to have ages ago about camera phones – everyone supported the fact that the best camera was the one you had with you. Here too, the best speaker is the one that's with you, the one that you can carry around and the

one that will keep your party going. This is why parameters such as loudness were factored into our test process. Be sure to go through the "How we tested section" before getting to the various price categories under which we've compared the 20 odd speakers next.

BELOW ₹5,000

This might be the most low end category in our test, but as it happens this is where most of the purchases actually happen; so in that sense it's the hottest category. There are a number of options for those seeking an audio companion on a shoe-string budget. Options available are from Indian companies such as iBall, SoundLogic (co-branded with MTV) and Portronics. There are new interna-

tional entrants also like HMDX with some quality products.

The speakers in this category were the most diverse in terms of their performance. Many of these speakers were single driver units packaged with a battery pack. As you can imagine mono speakers can only serve the sole purpose of giving you a volume upgrade over your phone speakers. Let's start with the units from Portronics. **The Portronics Drums and Sound BT** were decent performers but upped their game when it came to features. Drums was one of two speakers in the entire test to have voice cues. The moment you paired it with a device, a metallic woman's voice (with an Indian accent!) would announce the successful pairing. The build quality of the

Drums was slightly better than that of the BT, but the latter has two transducers (meaning: a slightly better sound). The Drums has some neat battery saving mechanisms that put the speaker on standby when no input is detected but it also had a design flaw. Perhaps in an effort to build on aesthetics, the device had a down-firing driver. The deflections caused by this muddled the sound considerably. Put the device on its head or on the side (if you're okay with it rolling off the table) and the sound improves. The **SoundLogic MTV Twister** has an entirely rubberised body and claims to be splash resistant. Since we couldn't find any Ingress Protection Rating defined we dared not put this claim to the test. Though the